LESSON 3

Articles

1.The indefinite article: *a/an*

2.The definite article: *the*

3.Zero article: *Ø*

Singular, countable nouns always have an article: *a/an* or *the.*

The indefinite article: *a/an*

We use *a/an* – the indefinite article – when we talk about something for the first time, or something that is part of a group or type.

- before unspecified singular countable nouns

  *She works in **an** office.*

- with the names of professions
  *He's **a** manager.*
- in expressions of measurements
  It sells at €1.75 **a** litre.
- before a noun to mean all things of the same type
  ***A** boutique hotel is **a** small, stylish and fashionable hotel that is not part of **a** chain.*

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We use *a* when the word that follows it begins with a consonant sound. We use *an* when it's followed by a vowel sound. This makes pronunciation easier.

*She has **a** university degree.*
*It took me **an** hour to get home.*

The definite article: *the*

We use *the* – the definite article – when the listener already knows which thing we are talking about because it was mentioned before or because there's only one of them.

*I'm going to take **the** dog for a walk.*
*Have you seen **the** car key?*
*They go to **the** school next to **the** bridge.*

- it is clear from the context what particular thing or place is meant
  *I'll meet you in **the** reception area.*

- before a noun that we have mentioned before
  *They had a villa in Cannes and a chalet in Innsbruck, but they sold **the** villa.*

- before adjectives to specify a category of people or things
  ***the** rich, **the** poor, **the** French, **the** unemployed, **the** World Wide Web*

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Zero article

When we talk about things in general, we normally use a plural or uncountable noun with no article.

Birds eat worms.
Water freezes at 0°C.
Children need a lot of sleep.

- mass nouns used in general statements

  (Ø) *Money is the root of all* ***(Ø)*** *evil.*

- the names of places and people
  (Ø) *Italy,* ***(Ø)*** *Japan,* ***(Ø)*** *President Biden*

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